

Christ the Redeemer

Rio de Janeiro's most famous landmark and the largest Art Deco style statue in the world



A colossal statue of Christ the Redeemer dominates Rio de Janeiro from the top of Mount Corcovado, its face directed at the rising Sun so that—in the words of its designer—“the statue of the divine will be the first image to emerge.” The idea of building a monument on the mountain was first raised in the 1850s, but it was only in 1921 that the Catholic archdiocese proposed a statue of Christ for the summit. The foundation stone of the base was laid on April 4, 1922—the centennial of Brazil’s independence from Portugal—even before the design of the statue had been agreed upon. Later in 1922, the Brazilian engineer Heitor da Silva (1873–1947) was entrusted with the design, although Brazilian artist Carlos Oswald and French sculptor Paul Landowski also influenced the final design.

An embrace for the city

The church raised most of the \$250,000 required to fund the construction of Christ the Redeemer, and workers and material began making their way up the mountain by train in 1926. Built from reinforced concrete and decorated with a mosaic of triangular soapstone tiles, the statue was completed in 1931. It stands 98 ft (30 m) tall on a square base about 26 ft (8 m) high, which is covered with black granite, giving the Art Deco figure an austere footing; the arms of Christ span 92 ft (28 m) from north to south.

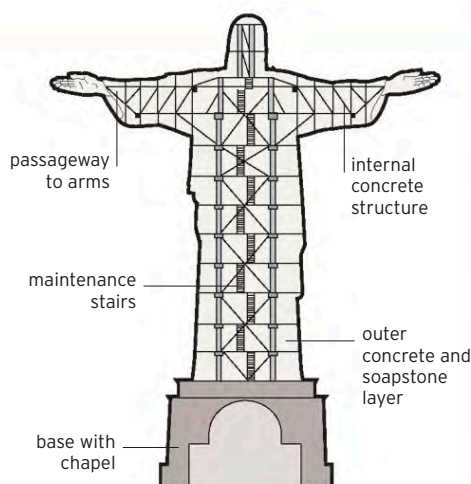
► UNDER CHRIST'S GAZE

The giant sculpture of Christ looks out over Rio and the Sugar Loaf Mountain, a constant reminder to the citizens of their religious duties.

Christ the Redeemer is the **fifth largest statue** of Jesus in the **world**

INSIDE THE STATUE

Within the statue are a series of reinforced floors linked by narrow staircases. The tenth floor extends into the arms of the statue, and a narrow passage reaches to the fingers. A hatch in the shoulder section gives access to the outside. A carved heart decorated with mosaic sits inside the chest of the statue. The hollow base of the statue contains the Chapel of Our Lady of Aparecida, consecrated on the statue’s 75th anniversary in 2006.



△ CONCRETE CONSTRUCTION

The 12-ft- (3.75-m-) high head of Christ is cast in concrete and decorated with soapstone mosaic.

